Age- and sex-standardised incidence of diabetes mellitus in Peru from 2016 to 2023

Carlos J. Toro-Huamanchumo Omar Silverman-Retana
Juan Pablo Perez Bedolla Daniel R. Witte Ralph Brinks
Thaddäus Tönnies

Introduction

The incidence of diabetes mellitus (DM) has increased significantly in recent decades with an age-standardised rate rising from 234 per 100,000 people in 1990 to 285 per 100,000 in 2017[1]. According to estimates by the International Diabetes Federation, the number of people living with DM in South and Central America is projected to increase to 52 million by 2050[2].

Findings from a Peruvian study showed a cumulative incidence of DM of 7.2% and an incidence rate of 19.5 (95% confidence interval [CI] 13.9 - 28.3) new cases per 1,000 person-years. These results indicate that the incidence in Peru is among the highest reported worldwide[3]. However, reports on DM incidence in Peru remain limited, and the few available studies have been conducted primarily in urban populations.

The objective of this study is to estimate age-specific, sex-specific, and age-standardised incidence rates of diabetes in Peru between 2016 and 2023 by implementing the illness–death model.

Methods

An observational study will be conducted using cross-sectional data from the Demographic and Family Health Surveys (ENDES) for the period 2018–2023. Based on these surveys, prevalent cases of DM at the national level in Peru will be identified. The ENDES survey is conducted annually and is representative of the entire Peruvian territory, providing information on demographic characteristics, health indicators across the life course, communicable and non-communicable diseases, and related determinants.

The target population comprises households and their resident members, with data collected by trained personnel who visit the selected households. The instruments for data collection include interviews and laboratory measurements[4]. To identify prevalent cases of DM, the following question will be used as an indicator: "Has a doctor ever diagnosed you with diabetes or 'high sugar' in your blood?". This question offers the response options: "yes", "no", and "don't know/don't remember"[4]. For the analyses, only participants who respond "yes" or "no" will be included, excluding those who answer "don't know/don't remember".

Subsequently, age-specific prevalence of DM will be estimated by sex for the years 2016-2023. Age groups will be categorised in five-year intervals from 15-19 years up to 80+ years, with 95% CI calculated using logit transformation. Additionally, data from the United Nations World Population Prospects will be used to obtain mortality rates in the general population for the years 2016-2023.

To estimate incidence using the approach described below, information on the mortality rate ratio (MRR) comparing people with and without DM is required. As no studies to date have estimated the MRR for Peru, several scenarios will be modelled, varying the MRR within a plausible range as done in previous studies[5]. Both the ENDES survey data and the United Nations mortality data are publicly available.

To estimate the incidence rate of DM for the years 2018-2023, an illness-death model will be applied using a partial differential equation. This method has previously been used in the context of chronic non-communicable diseases[6,7]. This model is based on a mathematical relationship between the prevalence of DM, the mortality rate in the general population, and the MRR. Transitions between these states are characterised by incidence rates (no diabetes $\rightarrow$ diabetes) and mortality rates rates (no diabetes $\rightarrow$ death; diabetes $\rightarrow$ death).

The partial differential equation used to estimate the incidence of DM was developed by Brinks and Landwehr[6] and describes the change in prevalence with respect to age and calendar time:

$$i = \frac{\left(\frac{\partial}{\partial a} + \frac{\partial}{\partial t}\right) p}{1 - p} + m \cdot \frac{p(MRR - 1)}{p(MRR - 1) + 1} \tag{1}$$

Where i represents the incidence of DM, p represents the prevalence, and $\left(\frac{\partial}{\partial a} + \frac{\partial}{\partial t}\right) p$ denotes the temporal change in prevalence as a function of age a and calendar time t.Additionally, m reflects the mortality rate of the general population and MRR the mortality rate ratio. Therefore, the incidence rate can be calculated from estimates of the prevalence of DM, its temporal change by age and calendar time, the overall mortality rate, and the ratio of mortality rates between individuals with and without DM.

All statistical analyses will be performed in the R software version 4.5.0[8].

Discussion

Understanding the epidemiological profile of DM in the Peruvian population is essential for informing public health strategies aimed at prevention and control[9]. There is a lack of cohort studies conducted in Latin American countries, which makes it unfeasible to directly estimate the incidence of DM. For this reason, this study will apply the illness-death model to estimate diabetes incidence using prevalence data from nationally representative surveys and mortality data from official vital statistics. This model has previously been implemented with Mexican data to calculate DM incidence rates for the period 2003-2015[5].

This study has some limitations. Diabetes status is defined by self-report and therefore may introduce information bias. Additionally, it is not possible to distinguish between type 1 and type 2 diabetes, which is important given the increasing incidence of type 1 diabetes reported in recent years[10]. On the other hand, a strength of this study is the use of nationally representative survey data from Peru. These findings will contribute recent estimates of diabetes incidence in Peru, which have not been previously reported and may inform public health planning and resource allocation.

References

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